



Senior Research Associate - Flexible work location: Local/ Office-Assigned

April 13, 2026

Are you passionate about using research to drive meaningful impact? The Center for Rural Affairs is seeking a Senior Research Associate to support and strengthen research efforts across a diverse range of topic areas, advancing the Center's mission through rigorous, thoughtful, and accessible analysis. This role works closely with staff and leadership to design and execute research projects, identify and evaluate high quality information sources, and translate findings into clear compelling data that informs strategy, policy, and community engagement. The ideal candidate is collaborative, intellectually curious, and skilled at connecting data, research, and real world impact that will help ensure the Center's work is evidence based and responsive to the needs of the communities we serve.

Read on. We might be looking for you.

In this role, you'll support and shape research projects that expand the Center's impact across rural communities by designing studies, gathering and evaluating data, and translating findings into clear actionable insights. Working across teams, your efforts will help inform strategy, strengthen programs, and ensure communities have access to the knowledge and tools needed to drive meaningful change.

Who We Are

The Center for Rural Affairs is a dynamic, energetic non-profit organization working to build a better rural future for all. We've done this work for more than 50 years and we do it from rural places with a flexible work environment. The Center focuses on capital access, community capacity, and policy advocacy strategies with work in areas of food systems, community resources, small business support, and environment and resilience. The Center's work is rooted in our mission-aligned values. We believe that a diversity of people and ideas strengthens our work, our workplace, and our communities. We take equal opportunity seriously and we welcome applicants from a variety of backgrounds. Additional information can be found at www.cfra.org.

What You'll Do

The Senior Research Associate reports to the Chief of Programs and will work closely with program directors and related staff, and has the following responsibilities:

- Collaborate with staff across the Center to design research projects aligned with the Center's strategic priorities.
- Support research projects such as funding proposals, program reports, policy and legislative analyses, economic studies, geospatial mapping, and participant and community input.
- Advise and support staff in finding, evaluating, and collecting relevant information from reliable sources, including government and public datasets, academic research, and community conversations.
- Identify opportunities to expand the Center's research efforts in ways that advance the organizational mission.

Who You Are & Keys to Success (the must-haves)

To be successful in this job, you will excel in five areas:

- **Relationship building:** You know how to talk with people to learn what needs they have through conversation and inquiry. People trust you because you're efficient with their time and have the best interests in mind. You're able to build networks, as well as alliances, and find points of collaboration even when there are competing interests on your time. You develop and maintain strong, collaborative working relationships with a diverse group of stakeholders.
- **Drive to achieve results:** You know how to leverage your strengths to achieve your own ambitious goals, and you anticipate hurdles as merely a momentary inconvenience. You possess a competitive drive and are creative in approaches. You set a high bar and meet it because you think three (or more) steps ahead to come up with pragmatic, yet innovative, solutions. You have an affinity for the details.
- **Inclusive leadership and management:** You approach leadership in your work with a mindset of "power with" rather than "power over" and include others with lived experience and expertise in decision-making. You use resources wisely and can provide clear direction to staff, partners, or contractors to leverage time and resources for impact.
- **Setting and managing priorities:** You have experience managing multiple projects and keeping from slipping through the cracks. You use resources wisely and can provide clear direction to staff, partners, or consultants to leverage time and talent for impact. You understand the importance of effective delegation and empower others by assigning responsibilities that align with their strengths to maximize efficiency and results.
- **Commitment to social justice:** You recognize and address barriers to accessing capital, resources, and information. You recognize how your own identities show up in the work, and welcome, receive, and act on feedback with an eye toward continuous learning about difference to overcome barriers. You recognize that investment in communities, people, and entrepreneurship are pathways to better outcomes. You're a leader (or willing to become a leader) in incorporating the Center's Values effectively into internal processes, external programming and communications, and working relationships, as well as identifying opportunities to build your own capacity to center these values into your work.

If you were here right now, you would be:

- Learning from current Center staff about ongoing and anticipated research projects, both short and long term.
- Partnering with program staff to design, execute, and report on high-quality projects and present research findings to a range of audiences.
- Supporting the development of new research project concepts to contribute to grant funding applications.
- Innovating ways to quantify, narrativize, visualize, and otherwise demonstrate the needs of and opportunities for rural communities.
- Sharing research output with board members, funders, community partners, policymakers, and general public.

You have experience with the following:

- Developing a range of different types of research projects as well as general project management and coordination.
- Encouraging a culture of curiosity and intellectual rigor across an organization.
- Building strong relationships and fostering collaboration.
- Working effectively with diverse groups of individuals and value differences.
- Aligning and prioritizing work to meet commitments and organizational goals.
- Developing and delivering multi-mode communications that convey a clear understanding of the unique needs of different audiences.
- Strategically creating competitive and out-of-the-box strategies that show clear connections

- Consistently achieving results, even under tough circumstances, developing yourself and other

What Else You Should Know

This is a full-time non-exempt position based in an existing Center office with a flexible work location. This position will require occasional travel by car to meet with community partners and colleagues, and in both overnight and out-of-state travel on occasion. A more flexible location may be considered for the candidate.

Compensation and benefits:

This position has a salary range of \$50,000 - \$64,000 with top-notch benefits that have a cash value of \$10,000 to \$29,500, depending on family status and tenure with the Center. Benefits include employer-sponsored health, dental and vision coverage, employer contributions to a Health Savings Account, 6% employer matching contributions to a retirement plan, a fantastic Employee Assistance Program, 12 paid holidays plus paid time off between Christmas Eve and New Year's Day, Friday Summer Hours from May through August, and vacation and sick pay.

The Center for Rural Affairs is an Equal Opportunity Employer and participates in E-Verify, is committed to the full inclusion of all individuals, and takes steps to ensure that individuals with disabilities are provided reasonable accommodations.

How to Apply

If you would like to work for an organization that has a national reputation as one of the top organizations in the country working to make rural communities more vibrant, apply by sending your resume, cover letter, and three professional references by [clicking here](#).

In the cover letter, please include:

- How your personal and/or professional experiences have positioned you for success in this role and any additional work, skills, or expertise you want us to know about.
- Please describe how your past leadership roles make you the right candidate for this role.
- Let us know how you heard about this position and tell us why you want to work for the Center